public-address system. I was seconds away from being disqualified, but the organisers let me play. The scare served me well. From that day, I have always tried to leave enough time and to avoid being late.

Players tried to enter all the events nationwide because they all offered points that counted towards the national rankings, constantly updated in every age group through Under-10, U12, U14, U16 and U18.

I enjoyed the experience, enjoyed the competition and enjoyed some success, designated as No. 1 or No. 2 seed in most tournaments and generally ranked No. 1 or No. 2 in the country in my age group.

As the years passed, and as I played in more and more matches and tournaments, I gradually learned to manage the nerves that regularly threatened to overwhelm me every time I played ('stick to all the same routines'), to cope with opponents who returned the ball with no pace, tempting me to try to hit too hard ('stay patient') and even to behave properly when I lost a match ('it is fine for you to be upset but don't show it').

After the sit-down strike on the roof of the clubhouse, my parents showed zero tolerance.

'Throw your racket once and you will be pulled off court,' I was told. I never did.

'Disrespect the referee once and you will be pulled off court,' I was told. I never did.

'Disrespect your opponent once and you will be pulled off court,' I was told. I never did.

Tennis became a huge part of my life. There was training almost every afternoon. Club, provincial and national tournaments were held throughout the year; they were generally scheduled during the school holidays, but when there was a clash with cricket or rugby, it was usually tennis that took priority.

Were people suggesting I would one day become a professional tennis player?

I think so. My forehand was decent but I remember that there was